

ESSENTIAL SKILL

People & Community

Share Skills. Share Work. Help One Another.

In a serious emergency, people may be the most valuable resource of all. A group becomes stronger when people share knowledge, divide responsibilities, check on one another, use resources fairly, and stay organized.

KNOW WHO CAN DO WHAT.

IF PEOPLE ARE GATHERING NOW

Hold a five-minute organizing meeting

1

Account for people and identify anyone injured, missing, isolated, or needing immediate help.

2

Name the most urgent threat: life safety, shelter, water, sanitation, heat, or medical care.

3

Ask who has relevant training and who is physically able to help.

4

Assign one lead and one backup for each active task.

5

Set the time and location for the next short update.

STAY WITHIN TRAINING

Community helpers support safety and professional responders; they do not replace qualified medical, fire, utility, rescue, or law-enforcement personnel.

START WITH PEOPLE, NOT ONLY SUPPLIES

Make a simple skills roster

List what each person can actually do, their level of training, and a backup. Ask permission before sharing personal contact, disability, or medical information.

NAME	SKILL	TRAINING OR LIMITS	BACKUP
Maria	First aid	Current certification	Sam
John	Plumbing	Home repairs	Ann

Include first aid, water treatment, cooking, wood handling, plumbing, electrical work, equipment repair, gardening, supply organization, communication, transportation, languages, and caregiving.

Have backups for essential work

Primary person + Backup person +

Written instructions

Prioritize backups for water, first aid, food, heat, sanitation, and communication. Let the backup observe and practice before an emergency.

Divide the work

WATER

Collect and protect

Treat, store, label, and distribute safe water.

FOOD

Inventory and prepare

Plan simple meals and track use.

SANITATION

Contain and clean

Manage toilets, handwashing, garbage, and hygiene.

FIRST AID

Assess and support

Give trained care and identify when professional help is needed.

HEAT AND FIRE

Control fuel and flame

Operate approved equipment and monitor fire and carbon-monoxide safety.

TOOLS AND REPAIRS

Stabilize problems

Handle tasks within demonstrated skill and training.

COMMUNICATION

Verify and update

Gather official information and post short, dated updates.

PEOPLE

Account and assist

Check children, older adults, visitors, and anyone needing extra support.

ASSIGN, DO NOT ASSUME

Check on people needing extra assistance

Plans should include children, older adults, people living alone, people with limited mobility, hearing or vision difficulties, cognitive or emotional needs, essential medications, medical equipment, service animals, or transportation needs.

☐ Ask the person what help is useful rather than deciding for them.

☐ Assign a primary check-in person and a backup.

☐ Confirm communication methods, medication, equipment, power, and evacuation needs.

☐ Record only necessary private information and protect it.

HAZARDOUS WORK SHOULD NOT BE SOLITARY

Use a buddy system

PERSON ONE

Performs the task

Works within training and stays focused on the job.

PERSON TWO

Watches and assists

Monitors hazards, maintains communication, and gets help if needed.

Use buddies for cutting wood, moving heavy objects, severe-weather work, checking damaged areas, and other difficult tasks. A buddy system does not make an unsafe structure or untrained operation safe.

Keep information clear

Known

Facts confirmed by direct observation or a reliable source.

Unknown

Questions that remain unanswered.

Next

The immediate action or decision.

Owner

The person responsible for following up.

Date and time every notice. Clearly correct outdated or false information instead of letting multiple versions circulate.

Hold short briefings

1. What has changed?
2. What is the most urgent need?
3. Who is doing what, with which backup?
4. Which supplies are running low?
5. What safety issue must everyone know?
6. When and where is the next update?

Keep operational meetings brief. Record decisions and assign a person to communicate them to anyone absent.

FAIRNESS REQUIRES VISIBILITY

Track essential resources

RESOURCE	AMOUNT NOW	USE PER DAY	RECHECK
Drinking water			
Food			
Heating fuel			
Batteries			
Medical supplies			

Prioritize life and health. Explain rationing rules, review them as conditions change, and do not let a few people use supplies without recording what remains.

A PERSON SEEKING HELP MAY ALSO HELP

Accept help safely

Ask new arrivals what they can do, what support they need, and whether they have relevant training. Verify credentials when a task carries medical, electrical, structural, or other serious risk.

Give new helpers a clear task, a partner, boundaries, needed protection, and a check-in time. Do not assign dangerous work merely because someone volunteers.

Know limits and manage conflict

Know how many people can be sheltered, how much safe water and food remain, what sanitation capacity exists, and which medical needs can be handled safely. Seek outside assistance early when needs exceed capacity.

Stress can make people impatient, afraid, angry, or confused. Keep disagreements focused on the immediate problem, use the agreed facts and rules, and ask: **What needs to happen now?**

RECOMMENDED SUPPLIES

Simple community kit

☐ Written skills roster

☐ Emergency contact list

☐ Household or resident list

☐ Notebook and clipboard

☐ Pens and permanent markers

☐ Printed emergency procedures

☐ Local maps

☐ Role-assignment sheets

☐ Backup list

☐ Accountability sheet

☐ Supply-tracking sheets

☐ Dated notice-board paper

AVOID THESE

Common mistakes

✗ Expect one person to manage everything.

✗ Depend on one person for an essential skill.

✗ Assume everyone knows the plan.

✗ Forget people with additional support needs.

✗ Allow rumors to replace verified information.

✗ Use essential supplies without tracking them.

✗ Assign hazardous jobs beyond someone's training.

✗ Ignore exhaustion or growing conflict.

✗ Wait until an emergency to learn what people know.

TRY THIS NOW

People practice

Gather the household, group, or participating neighbors and ask: **What could you help with if normal services stopped?**

1. Complete the skills roster and note training limits.
2. Name a lead and backup for six essential roles.
3. Identify people who have requested extra assistance.
4. Choose a reliable information point and update schedule.
5. Practice one five-minute briefing.
6. Identify the most important skill with no backup.

Arrange training or cross-training for the missing skill.

Quick checklist

☐ I know what useful skills participating people have.

☐ Essential roles have trained backup people.

☐ Responsibilities can be divided without overloading one person.

☐ Primary and backup helpers will check people needing support.

☐ We have one place for verified, dated information.

☐ We can track essential supplies and daily use.

☐ We know who coordinates each task.

☐ We understand our limits and when to seek outside help.

☐ Important knowledge is written down and shared appropriately.

REMEMBER

One person does not need to know everything.

Knowledge becomes stronger when it is shared.

A calm, organized group can solve problems one person cannot.

SHARE SKILLS. SHARE WORK. HELP ONE ANOTHER.

Official guidance and training

Connect local plans with emergency management, trained responders, and established volunteer organizations.

FEMA: Community Emergency Response Team
Basic Training

(https://www.ready.gov/sites/default/files/2019.CERT_.Basic_.PM_FINAL_508c.pdf)

Ready.gov: Make a Household Plan(<https://www.ready.gov/plan>)

FEMA: Individuals and Communities(<https://www.fema.gov/emergency-managers/individuals-communities>)

CDC: Get Involved in Community Preparedness(<https://www.cdc.gov/prepare-your-health/create-community/get-involved.html>)
